Y - 39,099
Andromeda Galaxy
A system named “Magnolia”
A planetoid named “Wolf” (a.k.a. “*Jungle Rock*”)

Part 1: ANT

Two months ago we sent Hadem into the primary ship: the Mariner, as a ghost. He lived in the walls, floors, and ceilings longer than most of us would have been able to. And for one month and twenty-three days, Hadem was able to successfully record the movement and planning of the Collective.

A week ago, the Collective sent a pod down to the western coast without any explanation. A small recovery team went to inspect it, all dawning bulk armor and blast shields just in case. They were able to tie a chain around the door to the pod and rip it open from a safe distance, and inside they found Hadem. He had been *satirized*: artful and intentional mutilation of a body, done after execution. Most of the time. It’s a final taunt to the dead and any sympathizers to them.

A lump of flesh I imagine was his foot was the torso, mangled fingers from either hand were molded into the paws, except for the pinky fingers which were spliced together in a mock tail. Two big toes were positioned as ears on either side of the head, which was his nose and some other unidentifiable chunks of meat. The nose was a pinky toe and the eyes were just that: his eyes. The art piece was finished off with a distinct boot print smushing it all down into a misshapen tartar. The meat puppet was accompanied by a sterile white envelope with a resin seal of a chain circle - the symbol of the Collective. Inside was a piece of paper hastily ripped from a spare manual book that had one word scrawled on it in oil: RAT.

I don’t see Wolf as my home world. I was born here but my first memory is of Rayaka, two weeks and two moons away from Wolf where I lived most of my life. Strangely, though, whenever I find myself talking with the other troops about “going home”, I’m not talking about Rayaka, I’m talking about the Zeppelin. I lived on the Zeppelin for two years before I was dropped on Wolf, it was an S-Grade Harbinger vessel with fifteen stories, two-hundred guns (barely used), and top of the line produce replicators to feed the entire

crew, cargo, troops, and passengers for a decade. In short: it was a very good ship that treated me and my like very well. Better than this jungle world anyway. On the Zeppelin I had to earn my keep by cleaning, caretaking, and occasional scouting. On Wolf, I earn my keep in shrapnel. I create, rig, plant, and detonate explosives. Most often for devices, machinery, and vehicles. Things to slow the enemy down, to cripple them. Sometimes crippling isn't enough, which means sometimes the shrapnel has to red and squishy instead of gray and solid. This "grotesque talent" (as Gunnie refers to it) of mine, has earned me the moniker:

"Dynamite," Monk calls out, "meeting. War room. Ten." I hold up a thumb to confirm that I'll be there. He walks away and I'm left to my devices.

There was anger in Monk's tone, probably still raw form the Hadem-rat incident; the two of them were close. I was not close with Hadem, but I did like him. He was decent and smarter than most of the people in our base. Even without a strong tie to Hadem, the ripples of grief his loss sent through our base was fuel enough for me to get liberal with my art. Since his death, I've added a dozen bodies from a Collective transport I set to blow by jamming its engine. Seven in a landmine circle set up a few miles east in thicker wood. Eight from an experimental "bunch-rig" where antimatter pipes drop from bellopine trees like fruit and explode instantly when hitting the ground; that one worked better than I expected.

I finish my work, fastening the screws and resetting the panel on a harvest android ready to finish its route back to the Collective on-world camp in the south. In four to six hours, the Collective agents will receive several bushels of dyeberries and five gigajoules of thermalshock explosion.

I send the android on its way and watch its flexible treads traverse the uneven jungle earth, right on course. Once its out of sight, I set my watch so I know when to listen for the blast, and I walk back to base for the meeting with Monk and company.

"We have ten days." Pagan began. In a few clicks, she throws a display up on the hologlass that shows a timelapse of the Mariner over the past twenty days. They've been looping the same wide circle, approximately three-hundred square miles around our base and their own. "We've had Finnegan, Raegan, and Usha reviewing all of Hadem's intel that he was able

to gather before his death. Most of it is useless to us now; information about potential strikes or invasions that have already happened. But in his last couple of weeks Hadem was able to capture, he gave us this:"

Pagan opened an audio file and turned up the volume for all of us to hear. Two voices began speaking, a man and a woman.

"*No good word from Mothership.*" The man uttered solemnly.

"*No?*" The woman urged, "*What are they saying?*"

There's a deep sigh coming from the man, "*Criticism, exclusively. They say we're spending too much time, too much man-power, too many resources on a sub-planet. I was in one of the meetings last week; Commander Crennick said we should have been better prepared for* 'pushback from the jungle-people'."

"*Awfully crude way to put it, I think. It's a jungle planet, but they are first and foremost: people, Paris.*"

The man's name was Paris, then. A name is enough to put a target to.

"*Well, Crennick is a crude man.*" a sound like coffee being brewed dribbles in the background of Paris' voice. "*He doesn't understand the importance of assimilation, of opportunity. We're called* 'The Collective' *for a reason after all.*"

"*Do you think he'll be terminated?*"

"*If he hasn't been yet, I'd be surprised if it happened at all.*"

"*Shame...He's a poor representative. I've already spoken to Rector Grace about him; she's assured me they'll be cutting his publicity significantly.*"

"*At least we have that. Though, while I disagree with his brashness...he does offer a fair point.*"

"*And that is?*"

I lock eyes with Pagan and I realize she was already looking at me, I don't know for how long. She giving me the same look she gave Hadem after we buried what was left of him under a shoddy wooden gravemarker.

"*Claiming Wolf is taking too long. We've lost thousands of troops. Thousands! We barely lost three-hundred claiming Trilla - a full sized planet, mind you!*"

"*They've got vigor.*"

"*What they've got is homicidal rage and a misconstrued concept of patriotism - or nobility - or whatever you want to call it. They've got explosives and battle tactics that tap-dance on the tightrope of being war crimes. They don't have the resources we do, yet we remain in a death-toll headlock. It doesn't make any sense! We shouldn't be spending this many Collective lives for the sake of these - forgive my crude reiteration - jungle people!*"

The woman laughs at the mans outburst, "*Does the Consort share your ideology?*"

There is a pause between the two voices.

"*I think so. I think they recognize the waste and are considering alternatives.*"

"*A Wash?*"

"*I can't say, I'm only speculating, but I imagine the idea has been tossed around. Or will be.*"

A new quiet falls between them; this time not of thought or careful consideration of words - but an intentional moment of silence for what might come.

"*Thank God I don't have to make that decision.*" The woman breathes, breaking the somber air between them.

"*Thank God indeed...On a lighter note, how are your-*"

The recording cuts out. No one says anything. Pagan steps in front of the hologlass and eyes the lot of us.

"This recording is dated eighteen days ago. The individuals speaking have been identified as Tutor Paris Autor and Tutor Maya Sayer; mid-ranking officers operating comms and transit between the Mariner and Wolf. Sayer has been involved in the Washing of one planet and one moon, Autor for one

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

moon and three planets. Safe to say, they will be able to sniff out the end when it's near.

The Collective is exhausted and desperate, they're running low on options but far from being out of resources. Which means only one thing...we lose."

A man four seats behind me begins crying. I don't turn to look.

"We've considered our options and we've decided on the best course of action: We have twelve teams assigned to gather our cargo, our refugees, and our troops if we can. Those twelve teams will take to Port Guerro, two days west, as soon as possible. There's four shuttles that have been idle there, so three teams will need to fit into each. Each shuttle should take off to a different rendezvous but we have a list of the moons that should be safe for a while. Amos will help you sort it out - Amos, start calling names and working out game plans."

Amos, a tall twig of a man burned three shades darker by the sun begins calling out for pilots who all stand and approach. Once twelve have been called, they walk out of the bunker to begin their next phase of planning.

"Next, I'm going to need everyone to leave except the following:

Monk. Gunnie. Jabber. Dynamite."

I should have known. God damnit.

In a few minutes, everyone else files out leaving us five alone in the blue glow of underlight and the hologlass. We all shuffle our way to the front seats to be closer to Pagan and the hologlass.

"I suppose you all thought that because we're scattering our numbers to the moons we're giving up. You thought wrong. Hadem gave us one more piece of useful information that we can exploit."

Pagan enhanced the image of the Mariner and tapped her tablet about a dozen times, adding file after file to the hologlass, splitting my attention between the blueprint of the Mariner and a few thousand words too small to make out.

The specialty troops (including myself), the privacy, the schematics. Pagan has a plan of attack, but I can't figure out what it is. I strain my eyes to try and find a correlation between the files and the blueprint but Monk beats me to it.

"The data core." Monk hums.

Pagan enhances again, highlighting the second-to-top story of the Mariner where a facility - about a square mile all around - appears to be riddled with, machines - servers and wiring.

"The data core." Pagan confirms. "This is one of sixteen rooms Hadem was able to infiltrate in his operation. Easily the most important one, too. The data core holds countless transactions across the entire Collective. Apparently they transfer the data to the Mothership at the end of every year and wipe their personal servers - no old news, plenty of room for more intel."

"You want to do what, then?" Jabber sat back in her seat, "Steal from it? Blow it up?"

"Both." Pagan lifted her chin, "And more."

Gunnie and I share a look. Pagan doesn't get this determined unless it means bodies will drop.

"The data core does more than just handle incoming and outgoing information. All the machinations of the ship pass through there - like a brain sending information down to the nervous system.

If there's going to be a Wash, I want it to be on the Mariner. Whatever they have planned, I want it to be shoved back down their throats." Pagan sat in front of us and scanned us. "Questions?"

***

If our intel is accurate, the Wash is happening today.

In the south camp of the Collective there is a small fleet of ships too unimportant to have a name. Pagan is in charge of securing one of the ships,

Monk is in charge of operating it once we're all in, Jabber is set to secure Collective outfitting for us, and Gunnie is firepower as usual in case it's needed. I am the starting gun.

Hunkered in a goliath bush, I have my eyes set on a bunker, not dissimilar to our own; inside, five to six voices echo off the walls. The door is open but security is active after my harvest bomb a little over a week ago. I suppose even success comes at a cost. My next option is one of the vents; there are two around the back, close to me, but they're blocked by a guard. A single guard, in steel-gray vestments, the thick fabric riddled with cooling veins, and adorned with Mercurian alloy armor covering the torso, arms, and head. I don't have a gun and I can't use any of the thermalshock detonators just yet. I need something quiet and reliable. My index finger and thumb - left intentionally open in my leather gloves - search my tool belt, slowly, as to not rattle any metal and draw any attention. My fingers land on a bowed handle wrapped in silicon, they feel down the tool to find a point - not sharp, but sharp enough. Needle-nose pliers, the metal bits about two inches long. Not strong enough to pierce armor, not long enough to do good enough damage through the coolant wool. I'd need to put metal to flesh to get the job done.

I turn my eyes to the jungle floor and find a rock the shape of my thumb. I arm myself with it and mark a tree to the right of the guard - if he turns on his thermal or sonar vision he'll be looking away from me.

I inhale until my lungs are full and carefully release all the air. Then, I hurl the rock, trying to move as little of my body as possible. It cracks against the bark of the tree and I watch the guards head jolt in its direction like a meerkat. I clutch the pliers in my right hand and stalk towards him. I don't blink from behind my goggles as I inch closer. The guard taps one of the buttons on his helmet, turning on one of the settings. He takes two steps forward but of course doesn't see any culprit. I'm out of his periphery now, and I let myself writhe upward to finish my hunt bipedally. He's only able to turn his head an inch back before I tackle him forward, pinning him on his stomach. The helmet covers his whole face, so I can't cover his mouth. I pull back the collar of his coolant wool and find a window of skin on his neck, without hesitation I drive the pliers in as deep as they'll go, twisting them deeper to make sure they drain the blood as fast as possible. Once the pliers are in deep enough where I don't have to hold them, I put a hand on the face of the helm and on the back and begin to twist as hard as I can to worsen the

wound and potentially break his neck. I don't hear a crack; it sounds more like grinding chalk between teeth. That, and the full-body shake before stillness tells me that I got him down for good.

I'm taking too long. If all has gone well, Jabber has the uniforms ready and Pagan is waiting to open the gangway for us. I return my pliers to their place on my tool belt and pull out a screwdriver to undo one of the vent covers. I don't bother keeping the screws or being careful with the cover, I toss it all aside. From my strap back I pull a single thermalshock grenade, shaped like a hockey puck with slightly rounder faces. As I set the timer for twenty seconds, I wonder what the last moments of the Collective officers inside will be like. I hear a laugh echo through the vents as I roll the grenade as deep as it'll go, and I know they'll die with smiles. What more could one ask for?

In fifteen seconds, I sprint only a quarter of the distance I need to close between the bunker and the shuttle that I hope is under the control of Pagan by now; we can't risk digital communication being tapped into at this point. The explosion goes off, anyone within the bunker is certainly dead. Three things occur next:

A pack of Collective troops flood out from the opposite end of the base to inspect the explosion, check for survivors, and search for me.

A secondary fleet of Collective march to the shuttles where Pagan is set to be. The Collective also cannot risk comms hacking from us, which means they'll need to send direct reports from the source.

Finally, I see Jabber and Gunnie rushing to the first shuttle on the docks. It takes me a moment to recognize Jabber, she's already in the Collective garb, but I recognize her silver hair.

I keep moving further and further out, I can't let the first flood of Collective find me. There's a split second where I see an opportunity - the first wave is occupied with survivor checks, the second wave is analyzing how many people to send up to the Mariner, and the gangway of the first shuttle opens, letting Jabber and Gunnie in. I run ahead; there are enough cargo boxes to keep my dead-sprint partially covered. The gangway remains open, I see the light from the inside of the polygonal shuttle as I close the gap and rush inside. The humidity from the jungle night is washed away by the sterile cool air of the shuttle interior. Entering the shuttle I hear shouting, bickering, coming from the front of the ship. Gunnie, Monk, and Jabber all seated

around Pagan on a pilots platform, visible through an open round door. They're asking about me. I hustle up the left curved stairwell leading to the upper deck and shout at them,

"Let's move!" They all turn their attention to me; Pagan only for a moment before returning her focus to the control panel to shut the gangway and begin takeoff. The other three are berating me with criticism and concern:

"What the hell took you so long?!"

"Were you seen? Were you identified?"

"Why would you only set off one bomb?"

I lift the goggles off of my head and begin removing my clothes, beginning with my toolbelt followed by my camouflage vest, "There was a guard by the vent. I don't think I was seen; if I was seen, I'd be shot. And I only set off one bomb because I only have twenty and we'll need the others for the data core. Jabber - can I get a uniform?"

Jabber hands me one of the Collective uniforms, similar to the guard I killed. Gray composite fiber dress shirt with a high collar and a flap that closes over the left breast, accompanied with black pants and boots. Satisfied with my answers, Gunnie and Monk take their uniforms as well and begin to change. Pagan is already in hers. Jabber outdid herself, there are Collective officer hats and Mercurion alloy pauldron armor. I wouldn't mind some, but I don't need it as bad as Gunnie or Jabber might, so I leave it to them. The clothing cuts up in some intimate places, it chokes me around the collar and everywhere else, but I have thirty minutes to get comfortable. The Mariner is just out of Wolf's orbit, which means it's a shorter trip for us.

Twenty minutes now. We all sit about in our uniforms, eyeing each other and passing the odd comment here and there about how strange it is to see each other in the clothes of our enemy. Some of us look good, but the outfit fits awkwardly on others. I'm looking around imagining if we were more than just mimics of the Collective - if we were really part of it. The life itself probably wouldn't be too bad in all honesty; top of the line medicine, key education, quick transports, entire planet systems united under one Collective. United a quarter of the time by genuine compliance, another quarter by threat, and the other half by force. How many Washes have

occurred in their conquest? How many more might if no one else fights back; if we let ourselves get too comfortable in these costumes? So many have already let themselves get comfortable. So many have already let themselves forget - or maybe they just don't care. Who's to say which is worse?

Oh well, no use in wallowing in the melancholy I suppose. You can't blow everyone up.

Ten minutes. Pagan put the shuttle on auto to join us and go over the plan again. Pagan would be the voice of our unit, covertly dubbed: Crew 99-J. If anyone asks any questions, if anybody requests names, paperwork or identification of any kind, Pagan would take point. Monk would handle the technical; any locked doors we encounter or alarms needing disabling. Jabber and Gunnie are, as usual, the primary offense. Their first task is to find weapons that make less noise than the heaters they have on them. I set a few bombs in the data core and once Monk has everything we need out of it, blow them up. I have to be thematic with the charges I plant apparently - Pagan makes sure to emphasize that, so does Monk. Jabber stays quiet but even she gives me a sideways look to make sure I'm listening.

There are 12 main servers for their Wash protocols, all of them need to go. There are fifty for their communications lines - which will take all the charge I have and then some. I'll need to find a way to stretch it out, or ask Gunnie to help me by blasting a few of the servers to cut down on the explosives needed. That's a risk though; it all has to go off together according to Pagan. If a bunch of grid lines begin dropping from the Collective's reach one-by-one, they'll catch on and the first place they'll look is the data core. It all has to be at once.

I feel a bit like a toddler getting a stern talking to. I don't appreciate it but I understand it. They've let me get my frustrations out these past couple of weeks, and a dozen odd times before then when this pitiful crusade of ours has particularly pissed me off. But I can't afford to let emotion man the trigger this time, and my team is making sure I know. After the initial frustration of feeling talked down to washes over me, a small part of me feels grateful; not only that they'd take the time to make sure I can do what I need to do, but that they all know me well enough to know that if I had it my way, I'd bring every bomb from our camp and slip one into the pockets of each and every Collective member on the Mariner and blow them up in a chain reaction so I could watch them drop, like a domino trail, with me as the final topple.

***

The Mariner is a pride of the Collective; the first project that their united home-planet, Kepler, could agree upon. Over two centuries old now, a trigonal prism stretching five-hundred miles long, one-hundred-and-fifty miles wide. She's a behemoth of metal and mettle, is split up into five primary sections:

Sector 1: Administration. Remote democracy, piloting, deep space politics for the people living aboard the Mariner.

Sector 2: Operatives. Communication, technological oversight, repairs, remodeling, upgrading, and just about anything that sends an electric pulse through the ship. This is where we'll be docking soon.

Sector 3: Resource development and distribution. Split between perishable and non-perishable resources - produce and preserves as well as wood and ore. Each key resource has a "mother" that is kept in an enormous vat of hormone elixir that keeps it growing exponentially without spoiling.

Sector 4: Weapons. Manufacturing and operating. We want to avoid that.

Sector 5: Fuel and Engineering; the people that keep the Mariner steadily drifting wherever it needs to go.

We land in hangar 2-D after Pagan tells a scrambled voice our crew code and shuttle ID. With the modulator, she, and the officer she's speaking to, sound as though they're speaking pig latin - backwards. We deboard in marching order with Pagan leading the front, and myself bringing up the rear.

It is surgically sterile in the 2nd Sector of the Mariner. Bright and clean white taking up most of the wall and ceiling, with intentional edging and detail scattered throughout. We're one of five ships in the enormous hanger - our footsteps and the voice of command sounding off announcements on the PA system. Only one other crew in the hangar approaches the interior gate; as we converge with them, I glance over and glimpse their faces. No

names to put to the faces, nothing to anchor them down in my mind. I wonder if remembering their faces would matter in the long run.

“Where are you in from?” The captain of the other crew asks Pagan.

“Vermouth, near Jirou river in the south.” Pagan says, not turning to face the other woman.

The captain makes a disgusted sound in her throat, “I hear Vermouth has been through hell these past few weeks. That true?”

“We’ve lost nearly a hundred people this week alone,” Pagan sighs, I fight back a smile. “I knew some. But it’s about to be higherups problem.”

“Finally,” The captain looks as though she’s just witnessed a motor crash, “terribly sorry for the losses.”

“It’s all part of the Collective.”

“True is.” The captain nods.

The two of them finish inserting their codes and credentials to the security A.I. and we wait patiently. A woman to my side, part of the other crew, eyes me. I try not to pay any mind, but she speaks:

“You’ve got cargo, then?” She asks, looking to the heavy bag strapped along my back.

“Only a bit.” I give her a short look and a half nod.

“Mind me asking what you’ve got?” Not an accusation, but cordial inquiry. She looks young, probably new to the Mariner’s crew; trying to make friends.

“Rocks and fruit.” I say, “Samples from Wolf’s surface for sector 3 to mull over.”

She smiles and returns her attention forward as the doors open and we’re let through, “Exciting stuff.”

“Very.” I adjust my bag tighter to my person and follow my team in.

The halls, a triangular mimic of the ships exterior, are an inverse of the hangar in color. Fluorescent lights illuminate black walls and floors with white

details on the edges. The floors have thin strips of color running down the center and jut off into various corridors, guiding any crew to various offices and depots. We remain on track with the red line, unbothered and undetected.

The red line takes us all over the sector; we journey down hallways, up stairwells, down other stairwells, through several doors, until somehow at the end of it - that red line bleeds into a red hallway. White overhead lights are one of the few outlying colors apart from the bold scarlet. Monk looses a breath and looks back to the rest of us:

"Jabber, Gunnie, stand ready at either end of the hall. Let us know if anyone's coming. Dynamite, you stay behind me and Pagan, you're going to need to work fast once we're in. Do you remember the primary servers you need to tag?"

There are four-hundred thousand servers in the data core - each the size of a refrigerator with five-foot gaps between them all. I need to target fifty. I remember the whereabouts of thirty-five. Monk sees that I'm lacking and slips me a piece of scrap parchment with fifty server serial numbers written on it. It's hard to read, but if I have enough time I can make it work.

I nod to Monk and he nods back with a smile, "Let's get to work."

I yank the satchel forward so the pouch of explosives sits over my stomach for easier access. Pagan stands to the side of an enormous set of double doors, also red, with a white triangle and exclamation mark identifying it as *High Temperatures - Security Personnel Only*. Monk takes point working at the scanner next to the doors. He pulls out his holoscreen and his fine tools - beads of sweat drip off of him as holds the holoscreen above the scanner to scatter the data - then he puts the fine tools to the port and - there's a loud noise. Something between a gunshot and a manhole cover slamming shut.

Several things happen at once: the white lights turn red - there is no other color in the hall now. The doors Jabber and Gunnie were manning shut too fast for them to get back in the hall with us. Jabber is shut on her side, Gunnie screams and I see only his right arm from the bicep up sticking into the hallway, twisted and broken from the force of the doors shutting. Finally, I see Pagan on the floor tending to Monk whose head is now gone.

Strangely, I can't see the weapon that ended his life so abruptly. What's even stranger is I can't make out any blood in all the red - it just looks like his head up and vanished.

I stay put as Pagan shouts for Gunnie to shut his mouth. She takes a few deep breaths and rises from Monk's body to face me.

"He fucked up." Pagan chokes, "We got this far being quiet, now it doesn't matter. *Aaron, Act 5 Scene 1.* Get us in that fucking room and get to work. I'm going to get Gunnie out"

"Aaron, Act 5 Scene 1" is a citation from Shakespeare's *Titus Andronicus*, notorious for being one of his bloodiest works. Pagan thought it would be fitting to have codes for each of us as a less identifiable way of saying "No holds barred". Pagan runs by me to get to Gunnie. I don't need to help them, I need to do what I do. Aaron, Act 5 Scene 1. I open my bag and pull out a bunkershot - a unique explosive I don't get to use very often. I stick the metal chunk, about the size of a clementine, to the slit of the double doors with tack - set the timer and rush over to the doors Jabber was manning.

As I wait for the burst, I listen for any sign of her. Nothing comes through.

The bunkershot begins sucking in a deep breath of air in the room, strong enough to make breathing only a bit harder for Pagan and I, for about ten seconds before the compressed air is let out the other end in one concussive eruption. A hole between the two doors the size of a dog door remains where the bunkershot was placed. I can't step through but I might be able to crawl.

I spare a glance over to Pagan who has given up trying to pry the doors open and has turned to taking precise aim with her Collective heater to try and shoot the arm off in as few shots as possible. I toss my bag of loose explosives in first before I put my head through the hole and begin squeezing through the inch thick doorway. Once I've fully slipped into the data core, I hear two shots go off followed by a loud scream cut short by the security doors closing. Pagan has left Gunnie and Jabber out to die.

I pull myself up and look around. I'm no longer drowned in red light, but nearly complete darkness save for the millions of tiny blinking lights emitting from the maze of servers surrounding me. Hot air, ninety degrees or more hits

me and the air is sucked out of my lungs almost immediately. I curse silently under my breath and regard the paper Monk handed me. In the faint light, I can see his blood splattered more prominently on my hand and on the paper, covering twelve of the fifty servers I need to hit. Pagan can fill me in on them later. Aaron, Act 5 Scene 1: time to work.

I plant the charges in patches, making sure that I hit the servers that will take out at the very least the surrounding eight with it. This makes my job marginally easier, because if I had to plant single charges for fifty fucking servers I would tell Pagan to do it herself blow myself up in front of her. Pagan still hasn't entered the data core - or maybe she has and we haven't connected. It's hard to hear much else over the deafening hum of hundreds of thousands of servers working nonstop.

I set the last charge I can before I need Pagan's help. I look at the paper again for any possible saving grace - I flip it over and see scribbled hastily:

Wait for my instruction. Set them off one at a time at my call - if it all goes off at once they'll use the emergency shutoff before it can have any effect.

Monk you blithe megalomaniac fuck - he expected himself to make it this far to tell me the marching order of bombs to set off. *Fuck*.

I run through the labyrinth for several minutes back to the doorway.

"*PAGAN!*" I call out, "Pagan, I need next steps!" I whip my head around to see if she's entered and just gone out of sight or if there's been a new development. I don't see her inside, so I peer my head through the hole I made in the doorway. She's there, with one Collective officer's head between her legs, unconscious or dead, and another; the girl who asked about my "rocks and fruits" in a bloody chokehold - still kicking and struggling.

Pagan turns her head up at me - both of her eyes have been wounded or scratched, blinding her, but she hears me.

"*BLOW IT ALL UP, GOD DAMNIT!*" Pagan screams at me, her voice horse and tired, like she's been strangled recently.

Neither of us notice the Collective girl grabbing the dead officer's heater before she puts it to Pagan's chin and pulls the trigger, sending chunks of her head raining down in the hallway. The girl gasps for air and crawls to the door, rasping and coughing.

She hits a button on the side of the scanner, "Several persons infiltrating the data core - *hostile!* Send Surgical Division!" As she finishes her order, I pull one of the five remaining charges in my bag, a screwdriver, and toss it to her. As its countdown begins, she looks at me through the hole and I see a look of somber recognition before I burrow back into the data core and let the shrapnel explosion take her life.

I can't set it all off. If I do, I'll cripple their communications and operations for a while but they'll recover and be back up in a month. Most of the servers I tagged are information and comms, but there are two next to each other that are operations and signals. The idea begins to form but the heat washes it out of my mind - I begin to strip layers until I'm in pants and nothing else.

If I can, somehow, someway, listen to the orders coming in, I can time the explosion of the operations to the Wash. If, a very big and dangerous if, I can do this - I can kill us both.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

2 Hours to Wash.

“How do you think they’re going to do it?” I ask, “Hurricane? Flood? Plague?”

“I don’t see why they don’t just send atomics, it’s far quicker.” Maya answers from behind her mug.

“It’s quicker but think about the fallout. It would leave craters in the earth, radiation to mutate the plant and animal life, and potentially sicken any recovery team we send down. The whole point is to eliminate the people and preserve the planet.”

“I still think atomics would be more humane. They wouldn’t even know they were dying until they were already ash.” Maya shrugs.

“Tell that to the people being turned to ash.” I grin.

The Mariner is by far the best ship I’ve worked on. My last post was aboard the Maelstrom; a combat-exclusive vessel. Ninety-percent of my time was spent idly performing upkeep tasks and training regimens, and the other ten-percent was dedicated to actually carrying out proper attacks with the rest of my Horsemen. I always liked the name “Horsemen” for my team; I don’t get that here, but I get “Surgical Division”. Not a bad name, and roughly the same expertise.

“Paris,” Maya asks, putting her mug away in the sink, “are you going to the announcement at the Master Lobby later? To see it happen?”

“If I remember, and if I have time to spare.”

“I’ll save a spot for you, just in case.”

Her thoughtfulness forces a smile out of me, “Thank you, Maya.”

She winks at me and saunters out of the common room. She’s always been extra friendly to me; at first I thought it was just her personality, but after a couple of years of working with her, I’ve noticed she doesn’t give everyone the same flirtatious approach. She’s a fine woman, very smart and very attractive - I’ve just never found a good time to speak to her about it. After the mass genocide of a planetoid also doesn’t feel quite right. I don’t want to wait

much longer though, it's gotten to the point where it's near impossible to let a day go by without thinking about her at least once.

I snap myself out of my thoughts and see myself out of the common room and begin the journey to the interrail - a shuttle system to transport Mariner crew all around the vessel at efficient speeds.

45 Minutes to Wash.

I stand at the platform and count the minutes until the shuttle arrives. It's late. There's no indicator of a technical difficulty or an intentional schedule change other than the monitor above the passage reading: "UNFORSEEN DISRUPTIONS". Last time that was used, word across the Mariner was that there was damage in the tracks that needed repairs. Later, I discovered a man had killed himself on one of the cars and they needed to deep clean it. Let's hope its not the same trouble again.

My concerns of suicidal passengers are swept away and filled with a different dread when I feel my bioscreen alert me. I look to my forearm where light illuminates from under my skin and flashes: "*Surgical Division to Data Core. Infiltration.*"

God damnit, I should've known.

15 Minutes to Wash.

Within minutes, I'm in the white flex-armor as the rest of Surgical Division and marching ten miles-per-hour to our destination. The T-visor on our helmets all displays the map trailing to the data core. Six troops travel behind me as we close in - and I can feel the temperature rising in the hallways below the data core before the display tells me how much it's heating up in our approach.

As we wind up the stairwell to the red hall, the internal coolant of the flex-armor starts up - and the respiratory aid helps me breathe through the wave of heat.

I send orders to the six Surgeons behind me - telling three to go to the left end of the hall, and the other three to trail behind me. They'll be waiting for my signal to infiltrate once everything has been scanned.

A body lies several feet away from the door I approach - a woman in a Collective uniform laying slumped on the floor with several holes in her gut. Scanners say vitals are gone - I kneel down and inspect the uniform for identification - once I find it, I check for forgery. It comes up as a perfect match with our tags, it appears to be real. I press further and scan the logs for matching personnel...nobody comes up. A perfect forgery for an imposter. Any hint of empathy or grief for a fellow officer fades away into the pit in my stomach; the people on Wolf have been working hard to get to this level of quality. I can't let it pay off.

Looking back at the womans hollow face, her round features and pale complexion remind me of Maya. She's no doubt at the Master Lobby now, waiting for the countdown of the Wash - it's been broadcasting since the hour mark. I hope I can get to see it with her.

I turn to the security doors and punch in the code to undo them, then send a message to the six Surgeons letting them know to stand by the doors and wait for further instruction. Red light still floods the room but I change the display to clearly see the differences of terrain, substance, and temperature. Four bodies on the ground, two missing heads, one with holes ripped indiscriminately throughout her body, another mercifully intact in death; new blood pools in a fifteen foot radius surrounding them. The heat blasting out of the data core makes it hard to differentiate the temperatures between much of anything, but I see that the primary outlet of the heat blast is a two by two foot hole in the doors. People aren't meant to enter without coldwear to keep them protected and level-headed during operations. This job looks too hastily done to have accounted for that.

In scramble, I call to the Surgeons, "Sterilize. Trace the order of operations - I want to know who shot first, who's on our side and who's not, and what they're planning. You have ten minutes." At the set of the deadline, they get to work recording and analyzing data - using the crime analysis A.I. system to trace back the most likely possible outcomes.

The metal doors to the data core have been rent grotesquely and the scanner I could normally punch an override code into is also severely damaged.

I pull the left sleeve of my armor forward and give it a firm twist to expose the burnswitch and lock it in place. I run my arm slowly down the seam of the doors to soften and melt the metal until there is roughly a half foot of weak metal edging the doors.

I step back until my heel is against the wall and I call out in a clear voice to any individual that may be through the doors, “This is Tutor Paris Autor, you have ten seconds to announce yourself and come out!”

Ten silent seconds pass.

It only takes three steps for me to close the distance between the back wall and the doorway - I hold my arms in a cross in front of me as I break through the ruined doors. Once I’m through, I shoot my right arm forward, bringing the armcannon from my forearm into my grasp.

It’s quiet. I could see through my T-visor in the hallway but in the belly of the beast, it’s no match and gets too foggy to see accurately. I push the lock on the helmet behind my left ear that pops the seams of the helmet and immediately lets the heat overwhelm my head. I remove the helmet and drop it to the ground; thankfully my flexsuit still cools my body but I feel sweat caking my head, face, and neck immediately.

Steadily, I stalk through the field of servers, jerking my firearm around corners in case the assailant is waiting for me. Sweat drips into my eyes, breathing is a challenge, and I can’t hear a damn thing over these machines.

Turning the corner, I see a strange lump jutting off of one of the servers that I haven’t noticed on any of the others. As I near, I notice it’s roughly the size of my hand and has wires connecting from it to the server. It looks too out of place. I hold my left palm up to the device and command the suit, “Scan.”.

A small cone of light emits from my hand for five seconds before showing a display on my left forearm reading: “*NG-EMP-X21 - ‘Shock-Jock’. Radius: thirty feet. Lethal. Remote trigger - no timer.*”

I give another command, “Trace.”

Several seconds of a looping light pass before a new display:

"*Detonator = one-hundred-twenty-seven feet north-east.*" A small blue grid appears with a blinking red dot at the edge of the map. I begin moving towards it, keeping an eye out for other explosives. I find five others as I close in.

"*Eighty feet.*"

"*Fifty-five feet*."

"*Twenty-five feet.*"

I mute the A.I.. I'm near the far end of the room and I see a wall full of bright screens looming above a panel I can't see the end of covered in an endless slew of multicolor buttons and switches. It hurts my head to look at but I know that they're near there.

I move in closer, "This is Tutor Paris Autor with the Surgical Division - state your name and surrender now or be neutralized!"

I jump the corner to see a woman, hunched forward with a streak of loose wires connecting from the control panel to a holoscreen in her lap. Her hair is short and drenched, her skin is red and peeling; she looks as though she's just come out of a hot tub.

"I will repeat myself one more time: I am Tutor Paris Autor with the Surgical Division - state your name and surrender now or be neutralized."

"Tutor Paris?" The woman groans?

I don't answer. I wait and watch as she lifts her head to face me - her eyes are dazed and it takes a while for her to focus on me properly. When she does, a lazy smile creeps onto her face.

"I know you." A throaty, dry laugh crawls out of her throat. I don't know her, and I'm missing part of a bigger picture. The holoscreen in her hand is the detonator, I'm sure of it, but I can't risk setting off a deadman switch yet.

"Thanks for the heads up."

"What do you mean?" I shout, keeping my trained on her.

“Don’t worry about it too much.” She sighs, turning her eyes back down to the holoscreen.

“Drop the device.” I demand.

“Hold on.” She holds up a finger. I charge up the weapon with a loud whirr so she knows its ready to fire - that I’m ready to kill.

“Drop the device now and surrender - you have five seconds! One!..Two!..”

“Got it -” *click*.

She turns the holoscreen and I hear an explosion sound off a few hundred feet back - instantly my finger tightens on the trigger and I put a hole through her throat. She drops to the floor, dead.

I rush to the holoscreen and inspect the data on the screen, and my heart sinks.

There are nearly twenty explosive devices planted around the data core - only one of which is marked red for detonation. The thing that captures my attention more is the fact that the Wash was triggered half a minute ago.

On the holoscreen, I select the one server that was destroyed - it took out six other servers in proximity to it. As I read the synopsis of the servers operative - I discover those six were half of the dozen servers specifically dedicated to Last Resort operations. Washes.

I have to get to Maya.

***

The Wash was a flood. Sector Four had prepared several hundred drop pods, collectively adding up to thirty-two million gallons of water set to drop at select points over Wolf’s surface. Only half made it down, still causing major damage and taking tens of thousands of lives. The other half erupted on the Mariner and spent the next four days spreading to the other sectors, drowning hundreds of thousands of crew members and causing severe

damage to the infrastructure. The worst of it came from when the flood hit sectors three and five; the bulk of the Mariner's tech center was drowned out, as were the nuclear engines used to propel the vessel through space safely.

Our shuttle is as big as a studio apartment, large enough for the two of us. I could do without the constant bobbing and drifting along the remains of the flood.

Looking up at the sky, the Mariner, once imposing and damning, is surrounded by a massive globe of water, like the carcass of a great old whale. My surgeons failed to make it off, as did many of my superiors, and my friends.

I made it to Maya, and despite her initial hesitant loyalty to the Collective, she left post to join me on an escape shuttle bound for none other than Wolf, freshly ravaged by the vessel I emerge from. The shit shuttle only had the range to make it here, but it has enough to keep us alive until we can be picked up. What frightens me now is the possibilities of who could find us first:

If the enemy finds us, we're almost certainly dead. Unless we lead with submission, which I doubt Maya would commit to. We can't feign escaped prisoners, our story would need to line up perfectly, but both of our lives are rooted too deeply in the databases of the Collective; they could find us easily.

If the Collective finds us, we'll be imprisoned and/or killed for desertion. They have love for their fellow man - but no tolerance for weakness.

Unless we are able to run or hide, if we're able to find any way off this drowned jungle rock, death is all that awaits us. That, or a life of hidden solitude. I suppose it's no better than what the people of Wolf had to deal with. I suppose it was inevitable that they would fight back; that they would hate us. That they would hate me. Looking at the Mariner, even in it's drowned state - it is a behemoth, an ever-looming threat of reaping, of death, of wrath. All we are is death, to them. All they've ever been to us is mosquitoes in the jungle, picking at our skin and draining us slowly, minim by minim - until a week ago when we realized all too late that we had let the mosquito get bigger than ourselves. The mosquitos were always going to drain us - the flies were always going to have our bodies. In the end, what difference to the naked eye is a metal mosquito to a flesh one? They both want blood, nothing else matters.